

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Corporate Strategy English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For corporate strategy, CEO office, transformation, corporate development, strategic finance, product strategy, and internal consulting teams.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Strategy Role, Problem Framing, and Executive Diagnosis

Clarify missing information before responding.

02 Strategic Choices: Ambition, Where to Play, How to Win, and Tradeoffs

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

03 Industry Structure, Competitive Dynamics, and Profit Pools

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

04 Business Models, Unit Economics, Capabilities, and Advantage

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

05 Portfolio Strategy, Capital Allocation, and Resource Reallocation

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

06 Growth Strategy, Market Entry, Partnerships, and M&A Logic

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

07 Uncertainty, Scenarios, Strategic Options, and Risk Posture

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

08 Execution Governance, Operating Model, KPIs, and Board Narrative

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop, or use the prompts at the end of this guide.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Strategy Role, Problem Framing, and Executive Diagnosis

Clarify missing information before responding.

CASE

An executive asks for a "growth strategy" but has not specified whether the priority is revenue, profit, or market entry.

Teach this move

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Vocabulary to check: Diagnosis, Ambition, Strategic thesis, Issue tree.

Model response

Which outcome are we trying to improve, over what period? Revenue growth, profit improvement, and entry into a new market may require different choices. Let's define the decision first.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Second-round challenge

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Language-check answers

1. B - Could you confirm when the review starts? The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".
2. A - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review? This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

05 • Conversations

1. Which growth problem are we solving? - The lesson's executive requests a growth strategy without specifying revenue, profit, or market entry as the priority.

2. Retention or acquisition behind the revenue concern - Separate fictional strategy diagnosis: customer acquisition is unchanged, repeat purchases have fallen, and leadership asks for more advertising. Causes are unconfirmed.

3. A capacity symptom needs a bounded question - Separate fictional strategy exercise: one service team has a six-week backlog, while capacity elsewhere in the company has not been assessed.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Efficiency has two meanings

In a fictional executive discussion, finance means lower total cost by efficiency, while operations means shorter customer waiting time. No preferred objective or numeric target is agreed.

Role A: You are the strategy facilitator. Clarify the two objectives and ask which decision the analysis should support.

Role B: You sponsor the work. Explain why the objectives may require different evidence and remain unprioritized.

Possible opening: Could we distinguish lower total cost from shorter waiting time before calling this one efficiency objective?

Success checks

- Name both meanings accurately.
- Keep the target and priority unagreed.
- Agree a bounded objective-setting question before choosing initiatives.

Add a complication: A participant wants a target announced immediately without a baseline.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Strategic Choices: Ambition, Where to Play, How to Win, and Tradeoffs

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

CASE

A team can invest in its core service or enter a new segment. The same staff would support both, and capacity is limited.

Teach this move

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Vocabulary to check: Strategic choice, Tradeoff, Activity system, Opportunity cost.

Model response

The two options compete for the same team. Expanding the core uses existing capabilities; entering the segment requires new ones. We should make the resource tradeoff explicit before selecting a direction.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. 'Better' already has comparative meaning, so it does not need 'more'. Naming the criterion and tradeoff makes the comparison useful.

Second-round challenge

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Language-check answers

1. A - Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less. 'Whereas' marks a contrast between two options.
2. C - An increase of one percentage point. Subtracting 6% from 7% gives one percentage point. The relative increase is about 16.7%.

05 • Conversations

1. Core improvement and market entry share the same people - The lesson's team can invest in its core service or enter a new segment; staff capacity is limited and shared.

2. A focused pilot or a wider launch - Separate fictional strategy exercise: with the same six-person team for a quarter, option A serves one segment and includes research; B serves three segments but has no research capacity.

3. Customization versus a repeatable service - Separate fictional strategy workshop: option A offers bespoke implementations with more configuration work; B standardizes the service but excludes some requested custom features. Revenue effects are unknown.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Support hours or development capacity

A fictional team can allocate two specialists for the next quarter either to longer support hours or to a product improvement project. Existing hours and project scope would otherwise remain unchanged.

Role A: You are the strategy analyst. Compare the alternatives on the same staffing period.

Role B: You sponsor the decision. State a preferred benefit and acknowledge the work forgone.

Possible opening: The same two specialists can extend support or work on the improvement project, so choosing one displaces the other.

Success checks

- Keep the two-specialist quarterly constraint explicit.
- State the benefit and opportunity cost of each option.
- Offer a reviewable priority rather than promise both.

Add a complication: A stakeholder asks you to announce both outcomes without additional resources.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Industry Structure, Competitive Dynamics, and Profit Pools

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

A market estimate is based on total industry spending, but the company can serve only one customer segment.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: TAM, SAM, SOM, Profit pool.

Model response

Total industry spending is broader than our addressable opportunity. I'll separate the overall market from the segment we can serve and explain the assumptions used to estimate our potential share.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. C - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.
2. B - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

05 • Conversations

1. Industry spending exceeds the serviceable segment - The lesson's market estimate uses total industry spending, but the company can serve only one customer segment.

2. A market-share aspiration is not a sales forecast - Separate fictional sizing exercise: a serviceable market is estimated at \$20 million, and a team proposes a 5% share target without acquisition evidence.

3. More revenue does not locate the profit pool - Separate fictional industry exercise: distribution has higher reported revenue than specialist servicing, but comparable cost data is unavailable.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Global spending with a regional offer

A fictional market slide uses a global spending estimate, but the company's current service is available in one region. That region's share of spending is unmeasured.

Role A: You review the sizing. Explain the gap between global context and current serviceability.

Role B: You prepared the slide. Identify the regional evidence needed without inventing a share.

Possible opening: The global figure provides context, but it doesn't establish the market our current regional offer can serve.

Success checks

- Distinguish global spending from current reach.
- Reject an unsupported equal-share assumption.
- Agree a regional evidence request and qualified sizing statement.

Add a complication: A sponsor suggests dividing the global estimate equally among regions despite no supporting evidence.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Business Models, Unit Economics, Capabilities, and Advantage

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

CASE

A new service has positive revenue growth but negative contribution after variable delivery costs. A slide calls growth proof of a sound business model.

Teach this move

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Vocabulary to check: Value driver, ROIC, Margin expansion, Right to win.

Model response

Growth shows demand, but it does not by itself demonstrate attractive unit economics. Let's explain the revenue and variable costs per unit before drawing conclusions about the model.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Second-round challenge

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Language-check answers

1. B - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed. This gives the meaning in familiar words.
2. A - How would you describe the next step in your own words? An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

05 • Conversations

1. Growth with negative contribution - The lesson's new service has rising revenue but negative contribution after variable delivery costs; a slide calls growth proof of a sound model.

2. A contribution calculation before fixed costs - Separate fictional service example: each job earns \$80 and incurs \$50 variable delivery cost; fixed overhead and invested capital are not supplied.

3. Owning data is not yet a right to win - Separate fictional strategy review: a company owns a historical service dataset but has not tested its usefulness for a proposed analytics product.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Automation savings exclude support work

A fictional service model shows ten minutes less manual processing per job, but any additional support work has not been measured. A slide claims total delivery cost fell.

Role A: You explain unit economics. Separate observed processing time from full delivery cost.

Role B: You own operations. Ask what support and cost evidence is needed to assess margin improvement.

Possible opening: Processing takes ten fewer minutes, but total delivery cost hasn't been established without the support work.

Success checks

- Preserve the ten-minute observation.
- Distinguish task time, delivery cost, and profit.
- Agree to measure missing work before claiming margin expansion.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to call the time difference a verified profit increase.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Portfolio Strategy, Capital Allocation, and Resource Reallocation

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

CASE

Two divisions request the same investment budget. Neither proposal explains what work would stop if it were funded.

Teach this move

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

Vocabulary to check: Capital allocation, Core business, Divestiture, Adjacency.

Model response

Could each division identify the expected benefit, key assumption, and activity it would deprioritize? That would let us compare the proposals as allocation choices rather than separate wish lists.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. For an ordinary future condition, the "if" clause uses present tense. The other clause can express the future consequence or possibility.

Second-round challenge

The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Language-check answers

1. A - If the scope changes, we will review the schedule. The "if" clause uses present tense; the main clause states the future response.
2. C - We can assess the addition and explain its effect on the agreed scope. This offers a useful next step while keeping the approval and scope question open.

05 • Conversations

1. Two investment requests need displaced-work choices - The lesson's two divisions request the same investment budget; neither explains what work would stop if funded.

2. Funding a pilot by deferring a rollout - Separate fictional portfolio exercise: a team has a fixed \$100,000 budget. A \$20,000 adjacency pilot could be funded only by reducing a planned \$100,000 core rollout to \$80,000; approval is pending.

3. A divestiture idea cannot fund spending yet - Separate fictional portfolio review: a team proposes selling a noncore unit to fund investment, but no buyer, valuation, or sale timing is confirmed.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Shared specialists block two funded projects

Two fictional portfolio projects each have budget approval, but both require the same specialist during the same month. Only one month's specialist capacity is available; project sequencing is undecided.

Role A: You manage the portfolio. Explain why funding approval doesn't resolve the staffing conflict.

Role B: You sponsor one project. Offer a sequencing proposal and state what would be delayed.

Possible opening: Both budgets are approved, but the shared specialist cannot cover both projects in the same month.

Success checks

- Separate budget from specialist capacity.
- Offer a concrete sequencing tradeoff.
- Keep the changed delivery commitments subject to review.

Add a complication: A sponsor asks you to confirm parallel delivery because the money is already allocated.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Growth Strategy, Market Entry, Partnerships, and M&A Logic

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

An acquisition proposal lists possible cost savings. No integration plan or implementation estimate has been prepared.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: Market entry, Build-buy-partner, Synergy, PMI.

Model response

These are potential synergies, not confirmed savings. I'll distinguish the opportunity from the work and cost required to achieve it so the proposal presents a balanced strategic case.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. C - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.
2. B - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

05 • Conversations

1. Possible synergies without an integration estimate - The lesson's acquisition proposal lists possible cost savings but has no integration plan or implementation estimate.

2. A partnership discussion is not secured market access - Separate fictional market-entry exercise: a potential distributor has expressed interest, but no agreement, coverage commitment, or commercial terms are established.

3. Overlapping teams do not prove removable costs - Separate fictional acquisition exercise: both firms have customer-support teams, but workload, service requirements, and integration costs have not been assessed.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A build estimate excludes customer support

A fictional build-buy-partner comparison prices the build option's software development but omits ongoing customer support. The other options include support estimates. No preferred route is approved.

Role A: You review the strategy case. Identify the scope mismatch and limit the cost conclusion.

Role B: You own the build proposal. Ask for support requirements and retain the estimate as partial.

Possible opening: The build figure excludes customer support, so it isn't yet comparable with the other two estimates.

Success checks

- Identify the omitted support scope.
- Keep the build total and route preference unconfirmed.
- Agree a consistent-scope assessment before ranking options.

Add a complication: A sponsor wants to call building the cheapest route before the missing work is costed.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Uncertainty, Scenarios, Strategic Options, and Risk Posture

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

CASE

A planning workshop has a base case and a downside case. The team wants to call one a prediction.

Teach this move

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Vocabulary to check: Scenario planning, Residual uncertainty, Trigger indicator, Strategic option.

Model response

These scenarios explore different conditions; neither is a promise about the future. Let's identify the signals we would monitor and which decisions we would revisit if conditions changed.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. 'Better' already has comparative meaning, so it does not need 'more'. Naming the criterion and tradeoff makes the comparison useful.

Second-round challenge

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Language-check answers

1. B - Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less. 'Whereas' marks a contrast between two options.
2. A - An increase of one percentage point. Subtracting 6% from 7% gives one percentage point. The relative increase is about 16.7%.

05 · Conversations

1. Comparing scenarios without naming a prediction - Separate fictional quarterly planning exercise: option A reserves capacity for 100 jobs at a total quarterly cost of \$10,000; B reserves 60 jobs for \$6,000. Both cover the same service and quarter. Base-case demand is 90 jobs; downside demand is 50. Demand figures are assumptions, and revenue is unestimated.

2. A short lease preserves flexibility at a higher cost - Separate fictional strategy exercise: a one-year facility option costs more annually but preserves an earlier exit; a three-year option costs less annually but commits longer. Other terms are unassessed.

3. A review trigger is not an automatic expansion order - Separate fictional plan: two consecutive months above a demand threshold trigger strategy review, not automatic expansion. Only one month qualifies. For the coming month, preparation-only would cost \$2,000 for a capacity assessment and create no external contract; immediate expansion would cost \$12,000 monthly under a six-month capacity contract. Neither option is approved.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A reversible pilot versus a permanent rollout

A fictional strategy team compares a three-month pilot that can be stopped at review with a permanent rollout requiring a longer commitment. Costs and customer outcomes are not yet estimated.

Role A: You are the strategy analyst. Compare commitment and learning while preserving missing economic information.

Role B: You sponsor the choice. Explain which flexibility matters and ask what would trigger further investment.

Possible opening: The pilot provides an earlier review point, whereas the rollout commits us longer; their costs remain unestimated.

Success checks

- State the three-month review point and longer rollout commitment.
- Avoid claiming reversibility removes all risk or cost.
- Agree evidence needed for the next investment decision.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to call the pilot risk-free because it can be stopped.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Execution Governance, Operating Model, KPIs, and Board Narrative

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

CASE

A board presentation has twelve metrics but no clear request. The sponsor needs approval for a limited pilot.

Teach this move

Summarize the issue neutrally, invite missing perspectives, and distinguish discussion from decision. State who can decide and record any unresolved question. Do not assume silence means agreement.

Vocabulary to check: Operating model, Decision rights, KPI, Board narrative.

Model response

The decision today is whether to authorize the pilot. I'll lead with that request, the proposed scope, and the measures for reviewing it, then use the remaining metrics as supporting detail.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised question gives people a way to raise a concern. Silence can have several meanings, especially in unfamiliar or unequal-power situations.

Second-round challenge

A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Language-check answers

1. A - We haven't heard from the remote team yet; what is your view? It invites participation without interpreting silence as consent.
2. C - Approval is pending; the sponsor will review the two options. This distinguishes discussion from approval and identifies the next reviewer.

05 · Conversations

1. Twelve metrics and one missing request - Separate fictional extension of the lesson: a twelve-metric board presentation seeks approval for a four-week, twenty-account pilot. Operations estimates ten support hours weekly, but only six are available. Additional staffing and pilot approval are unconfirmed; the board holds approval authority.

2. A KPI owner is not automatically the decision owner - Separate fictional pilot: conversion improved, and analytics owns reporting that KPI. The sponsor alone decides extension. A proposed fifty-client extension requires twenty support hours weekly; operations has twelve available. Additional coverage is unconfirmed, and extension is unapproved.

3. A steering meeting ends with an unresolved owner - Separate fictional execution review: commercial and operations teams each assume the other owns customer onboarding in a proposed service; no ownership decision has been made.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A board discussion praised the pilot but did not approve expansion

A fictional board discussion praised pilot learning but deferred the expansion decision until costs are reviewed. The draft internal update says expansion approved. Finance has not supplied the cost review.

Role A: You facilitate the follow-up. Restate the actual decision and invite finance's missing input.

Role B: You sponsor the pilot. Confirm the deferred decision and identify who will bring the cost review.

Possible opening: The board welcomed the learning but deferred expansion pending the cost review; approval has not been given.

Success checks

- Separate positive discussion from approval.
- Identify the pending finance input.
- Close with accurate decision status and a named follow-up responsibility.

Add a complication: A team lead wants to begin expansion because the feedback sounded positive.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-06. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Adapt a partner or class activity

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Corporate Strategy English

Professional audience: corporate strategy, CEO office, transformation, corporate development, strategic finance, product strategy, and internal consulting teams

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Lesson 01: Strategy Role, Problem Framing, and Executive Diagnosis

Original fictional case: An executive asks for a "growth strategy" but has not specified whether the priority is revenue, profit, or market entry.

Language workshop: Ask a precise question

Communication goal: Clarify missing information before responding.

Language guidance: Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): When you say ..., do you mean ...? / Could you clarify which ...? / So, my understanding is Is that right?

Vocabulary: Diagnosis: Explanation of the strategic problem, its cause, and why it matters now. / Ambition: High-level performance or market position the company wants to achieve. / Strategic thesis: Argument for why a course of action should create advantage or value. / Issue tree: Structured breakdown of a problem into analyzable questions.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Which outcome are we trying to improve, over what period? Revenue growth, profit improvement, and entry into a new market may require different choices. Let's define the decision first.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Adapt this material for a teaching session

1. Ask me one brief planning question covering learner support needs, group size and available time. Offer a default of two B2 learners and 20 minutes. Stop and wait; use the default only if I choose it.
2. Create a timed plan using the supplied case or dialogue, its actual terminology and one narrow language goal. Include an individual first attempt, partner exchange, focused feedback and a retry. Keep the total within the time I choose. State what the learner should be able to communicate at the end.
3. Provide separate role cards for two or three professional speakers. Each card needs an objective, known information and one question to resolve. Label any invented private information as a variation; do not contradict shared facts. Do not place the model answer on the learner cards.
4. Add a B1 support option with useful frames, a B2 independent task and a C1 extension involving a plausible competing constraint. Maintain the same professional meaning across levels. Explain unfamiliar terms without removing the field's normal language. Include a workable solo alternative.
5. Put teacher notes and suggested responses in a clearly separate section after the learner material. Include likely misunderstandings and a short observation checklist for facts, clarity, tone and next step. Accept multiple successful formulations. Finish with one exit question and a delayed-recall task; identify what the teacher should check before use.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Adjust tone and register

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Corporate Strategy English

Professional audience: corporate strategy, CEO office, transformation, corporate development, strategic finance, product strategy, and internal consulting teams

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Lesson 01: Strategy Role, Problem Framing, and Executive Diagnosis

Original fictional case: An executive asks for a "growth strategy" but has not specified whether the priority is revenue, profit, or market entry.

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END REFERENCE

TASK: Match the language to the listener

1. Choose a short message or utterance from the reference and quote it exactly. Identify its purpose and likely audience. Ask me to choose a new audience: a close colleague, a decision-maker, or an external reader who may not know the jargon. Stop and wait.
2. Ask me to adapt that message for the chosen reader, keeping its facts and degree of certainty unchanged. Offer a short frame only if I request help. Wait for my attempt before showing alternatives.
3. Discuss at most three choices in my version: directness, specialist vocabulary and interpersonal tone. Explain when a direct request is clearer than extra politeness, and when an unfamiliar abbreviation needs expansion. Avoid cultural stereotypes or claims that one nationality always communicates a certain way.
4. Show two natural alternatives, such as a concise spoken version and a more explicit written version. Explain the tradeoff in each. Do not turn a request into an order, a possibility into a promise, or a pending decision into approval.
5. Ask me to respond to one realistic follow-up from the new reader, then wait. Finish by asking me to adapt the message for a second audience without losing its core meaning. Give feedback only after the attempt.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level